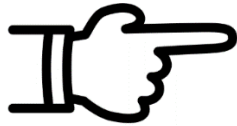


PEARLC - 10 markers (with an item), 20 & 30 markers

P – Point

Make a clear point that directly answers the question. Focus on one reason or explanation. Often it is best practice to refer to the item in your point – this ensures you do not forget! No mention of the item in your essays will lead to the examiners capping your marks e.g. you can only score 3/10 maximum.



E – Evidence to support the item hooks and own knowledge

Include one piece of evidence to support the item hooks in each paragraph (A*/B grade) or an example (C/D grade).



A – Analysis

Explain how and why this point leads to the outcome in the question. Develop the explanation rather than describing. Use key phrases 'this leads to...' 'this suggests that...' 'therefore...' 'consequently...' 'furthermore...'



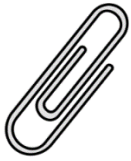
R – Reference to sociology

Reference the evidence you included - who discovered that finding? Give them the credit! You do not lose marks for spelling a name incorrectly or getting the year wrong or not mentioning the year at all! You can link your evidence to a sociological theory or concept to show knowledge and understanding. HINT – If you forget the exact reference it would be best to at least state the theory e.g. this research was found by a radical feminist.



L – Link back to the question

Explicitly connect your explanation back to the wording of the question. 'Therefore, this demonstrates that...'



C – Counter punch/paragraph

Briefly evaluate by offering a limitation or an alternative explanation. For top marks you should try to include a reference in your counterpunch/paragraph (A*/A grade)!



IMPORTANT: For 10 markers you are expected to write a counter PUNCH whereas for 20 and 30 markers, you are expected to write a counter PARAGRAPH. These sound similar but a counter punch is a simple criticism in one single sentence whereas in 20 and 30 markers the examiner will expect you to write an evaluative paragraph with examples/evidence to support the criticism to get top marks - counter paragraphs go far deeper than punches and are often also the same length as your descriptive A01 paragraph.



Memory version:

Point → Evidence/Example → Analyse → Reference → Link → Counter/Criticise



The Perfect Pearl

Click the link below to watch me explain in more detail how to write a PEARLC paragraph!



<https://youtu.be/8gEWKQPpNmc>

How can I use PEARLC when answering an AQA Sociology question?

Step by step walk through:

Below you will find a step by step walk through that applies my PEARLC paragraph structure when answering a 'Paper 2 - Families and Households' question.

Example 10 marker with an item using the recommended PEARLC structure....

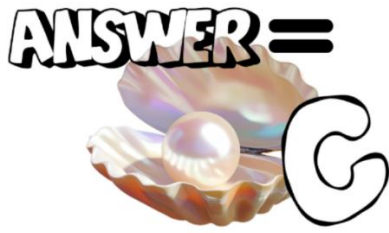
Families and Households Unit



Item A: Sociologists argue that childhood is not a natural stage of life but is shaped by society. In some cultures, children are expected to take on adult responsibilities such as work or caring for family members from a young age. In contrast, in modern Western societies, childhood is seen as a protected stage, with laws around education, child labour and safeguarding. Additionally, ideas about childhood have changed over time, with childhood today being very different from how it was in the past.

Question

Applying material from Item A and your knowledge, analyse two ways childhood is a social construct. (10 marks)



Hook 1: Culture

Point:

One way childhood can be seen as a social construct is that it varies between cultures. Item A states that “**in some cultures, children are expected to take on adult responsibilities from a young age.**”

Evidence:

Aries argued that childhood is socially constructed rather than biologically determined. Philippe Ariès argued that in a European, pre-industrial society, childhood did not really exist as a separate stage of life. He claimed that once children could survive independently, they were treated like miniature adults by wearing similar clothes, working alongside adults, mixing freely with adults. Cross-cultural **research** shows that in many non-Western societies, children contribute to work and family life much earlier than in Western societies. **Opie** conducted research in **Uganda** and found that children as young as **three years old** are expected to care for themselves and take responsibility for daily tasks. This contrasts sharply with **Western societies**, where children of this age are seen as **highly dependent**.

Analyse:

This suggests that ideas about **dependency, innocence and protection** are not universal. Instead, societies decide what children are capable of and how they should be treated. In cultures where children are viewed as **economically useful, childhood is shorter**, showing it is shaped by cultural expectations rather than age.

Reference:

Ariès (1962), Opie (1993)

Link:

Therefore, cultural variation supports the view that childhood is socially constructed.

Counter Punch (with reference):

However, **Pollock** argues that children in pre-industrial societies were cared for and protected by parents, suggesting that Aries may have overstated cultural differences in childhood.

Hook 2: Time

Point:

Another way childhood is socially constructed is that it has changed over time. Item A highlights that “ideas about childhood have changed over time.”

Evidence:

Postman argues that childhood is a product of modern society and may be disappearing due to changes in media and technology. He claims that television and the internet expose children to adult knowledge.

Analyse:

Postman suggests childhood only existed because **adults controlled access** to information through education and literacy. As this control weakens, **the boundary between childhood and adulthood becomes blurred**. Additionally, **Palmer** builds on this by arguing that changes such as family breakdown, consumer culture and screen-based lifestyles have created a “**toxic childhood**,” where children experience stress and pressure earlier in life. Together, these views show that childhood changes in **response to social conditions**, proving it is socially constructed rather than biologically fixed.

Reference:

Postman (1982), Palmer (2006)

Link:

Therefore, historical change supports the view that childhood is shaped by social forces rather than biology.

Counter Punch:

However, some sociologists argue that childhood still exists but has transformed rather than disappeared, with children continuing to be legally and socially protected for example, safeguarding policies in educational settings or child labour laws.

Examiner Feedback (Why this is top band)

- ✓ Item A applied clearly in both paragraphs
- ✓ Two distinct “ways” (culture + time)
- ✓ Strong, relevant sociological evidence with references
- ✓ Analysis explains *why* this shows social construction
- ✓ Balanced with evaluation
- ✓ Clear links back to the question

This would comfortably reach **8–10 marks**.

Reminder

You do not need two references in each PEARLC, if you can include one reference in each PEARLC that is great! If you are aiming for A* I would be willing to award 10/10 if a student presented me with a PEARLC with a reference in the PEARL and one in the counter punch (such as the first paragraph with Pollock in the CP) as this really does show incredible balance and depth!